

HOME BUYER'S GUIDE

It's more than just a house. **It's a home.**



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For most people, purchasing a home is the single largest investment they will ever make. But it's not just about dollars and cents. It's about having a place to call your own, designed to suit your tastes and needs. A place where you can lay down your roots, start a family, grow as a family, or just make memories to last you a lifetime. In short, it's about defining your own personal sense of home.

This guide is designed to provide homebuyers with a detailed look at the home buying process.





Key Questions to Ask Before You Buy

Before you jump into home shopping, start with two honest questions. Ideally, your answer to both is a confident “Yes.”

1. Am I financially ready to own?

Check your credit, review your budget, and talk with a trusted lender. This step confirms what loan programs you qualify for and what monthly payment feels comfortable. Don't forget to explore all your options—many buyers benefit from VA, FHA, or first-time buyer programs that make ownership more accessible.

2. Is now the right time for me to buy?

Timing isn't just about interest rates—it's about your readiness. If you've saved for a down payment, lined up financing, and connected with a real estate professional you trust, then the timing may be perfect.

At Team D.B., we don't just unlock doors—we help you read the market. With local expertise and proven strategies, we'll show you opportunities you might not have considered and guide you step-by-step to the right home at the right time.



The road to homeownership

Buying a home is a major undertaking that requires adequate research and careful analysis. Sure, there may be bumps along the way—or even a couple of pit stops—but the following steps will help make the journey as smooth as possible. Relax, you got this!



Prep and plan

An endeavor like this takes some serious thought, preparation and planning. Having a good sense of the kind of home, features and neighborhood you want ahead of time will be of great help as you start your home search.

And because most of us can't buy a home without financing, now would be a good time to gain a clear picture of your financial situation and exactly how much home you can afford. This will be of value as you research both your housing and mortgage options.





Buying a Home Made Easier

Buying a home can feel overwhelming, but it gets a whole lot easier when you have the right professional on your side. A trusted agent will guide you through every step—searching for homes, getting financing lined up, negotiating the deal, and making it to the closing table.

With experience and local knowledge, a good agent helps you avoid costly mistakes and spot opportunities you might miss on your own.

Once you're ready to buy, connect with a real estate professional who knows your market, has a strong track record, and puts your goals first





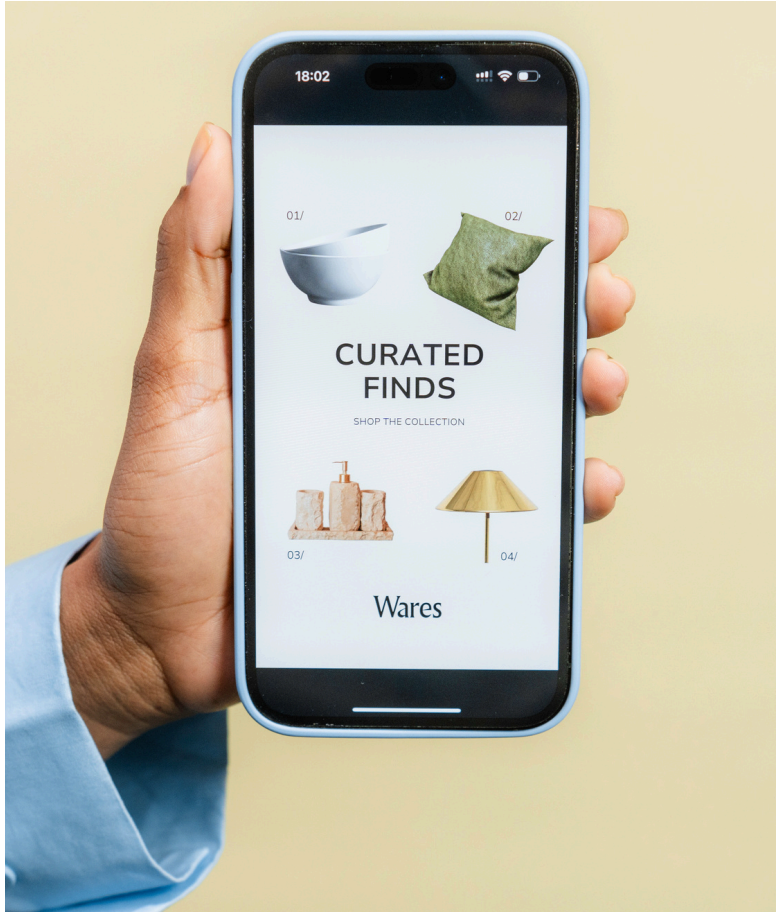
Get Pre-Qualified

Most buyers need a loan to purchase a home—and the first step is getting pre-qualified. This means meeting with a lender so they can review your income, debts, and credit history.

Once they've checked everything, your lender will give you a letter showing how much you're approved to borrow. Having this in hand helps you focus on the right price range and shows sellers you're a serious buyer.

Why pre-qualify?

- You'll gain a better understanding of how much home you can afford
- You'll be taken more seriously when making an offer
- You might discover you qualify for special programs that can help you increase your budget



Find the Home That's Right for You

Now comes the fun part – looking at homes! To make your search a

To make your home search successful (and enjoyable), start by separating your must-haves from your nice-to-haves. Knowing what you can't live without—and where you're willing to compromise—keeps the process focused and stress-free.

Use the Home Search Worksheet at the end of this guide to narrow down your top priorities and stay on track.

Some Perspective on the Home Search Process

- 51% of buyers who used the internet during their home search ultimately found the home they purchased online.
- Buyers typically search for 8 weeks before purchasing a home.
- 88% of buyers use real estate agents during the home search process.
- 91% of buyers say real estate agents are a useful info source.

Let's Talk Technology



Websites and mobile apps are powerful tools for finding your next home. From photos and virtual tours to neighborhood details, technology makes it easier than ever to discover homes that fit your needs.

That said, nothing replaces seeing a home in person. Online listings can't always show important details like layout, design, or craftsmanship. This is where having a trusted real estate agent by your side makes the difference. Your agent can point out things you might miss and provide expert advice to help you make the best decision.

Making the Offer

You've found a home you love—now it's time to make an offer! Your state or local real estate association likely provides the contracts used for home purchases. These contracts let you specify your offer price and include important details like closing dates, possession dates, your deposit amount, and other terms. Your real estate agent will guide you through these forms to make sure your offer reflects your intentions. They'll also answer any questions you have so you fully understand the process.

Once your offer is ready, your agent will present it to the seller or their representative. From there, the seller can:

- Accept your offer
- Reject it
- Or send back a counteroffer

If a counteroffer comes in, that's when negotiations begin—and your agent will be there to help you every step of the way.





Get Your Financing

You've agreed on terms with the seller—almost there! Now it's time to work with your lender to finalize your mortgage. This step includes:

- Completing your loan application
- Confirming your down payment and interest rate
- Reviewing your repayment schedule
- Finalizing any financial conditions tied to closing

Because mortgages can be complex, it's important to fully understand your options. Working with a lender you trust—and having guidance from your real estate professional—can help you avoid surprises and make the process smoother.



Seal the Deal

It's really happening—you're about to become a homeowner! But before you move in, there are a couple of important steps to complete before closing escrow:

- **Title Search** – A review of the property's legal history ensures there are no claims or issues with ownership. Many buyers also purchase Title Insurance for added protection in case of errors or overlooked claims.
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- **Final Walkthrough** – Before closing, you'll tour the home one last time to make sure everything is in the same condition as when you signed the agreement.

These final steps help ensure your purchase is secure and that you're walking into your new home with confidence.





Complete the Settlement

On or just before your closing date, you'll meet with a lawyer, escrow officer, or real estate professional to finalize the paperwork. This step includes paying your closing costs, legal fees, and any taxes or adjustments. Once completed, you'll officially receive property title and all documents for your new home.

Jump for Joy!

Congratulations—you're a homeowner! 🎉 You'll likely get the keys at this stage or within a few days after settlement. Now it's time to pack, plan your move, and start making your new house feel like home.

Unless you're paying all cash, getting a mortgage is the path most buyers take. That means finding the right lender who can match you with the best loan options for your situation.

The following steps will help you secure a mortgage that fits your needs:

1. Do your homework

There are many loan types and programs available through banks, credit unions, finance companies, and mortgage brokers. Take the time to research your options—websites, books, seminars, and advice from real estate professionals can all help you understand the process and avoid confusion.

2. Be honest about your finances

When exploring your loan options, be realistic about what you can afford for a down payment and monthly mortgage. Being upfront helps you and your lender identify the best programs while minimizing risk and stress.



💡 Think Beyond Just the Mortgage

Your monthly payment isn't only about the mortgage itself. You'll also need to budget for property taxes, insurance, HOA dues, maintenance, and even future improvements. Listing these costs out helps you see the bigger picture and gives you a realistic view of what you can comfortably afford over the life of your loan.

3. Find a trusted lender or mortgage broker

When you're ready to shop for a loan, you'll likely work with either a direct lender or a mortgage broker.

Direct lenders make their own decisions and offer in-house loan products.

Mortgage brokers connect you with multiple lenders, giving you more options and sometimes better rates, though they may charge a fee.

A knowledgeable real estate professional can often point you to reliable lenders or brokers they've worked with before.

4. Make a smart mortgage choice

Choosing the right loan means understanding the different types of mortgages, rates, and terms. Here are two common options:

Fixed-Rate Mortgages: Your interest rate stays the same for the entire life of the loan. This gives you predictable payments and protection from rising interest rates, making it easier to budget. Keep in mind that shorter loan terms (like 15 years) usually have lower rates but higher monthly payments compared to a 30-year loan.

Adjustable-Rate Mortgages (ARMs): These start with a lower interest rate, which can save you money upfront. However, the rate can change after the initial fixed period, which means your payment could go up later.

Your choice depends on your financial comfort zone, long-term plans, and how much flexibility you want with your monthly payments

Adjustable-Rate Mortgages (ARM)

ARMs have interest rates that can rise or fall depending on economic conditions. They are often tied to an index, such as the U.S. Treasury bill, with lenders adding a margin (usually 2–4%) to determine the final rate.

The main advantage of an ARM is that the starting interest rate is typically lower than that of a fixed-rate mortgage—sometimes by a quarter point to two points or more. However, this rate isn't permanent. It will adjust periodically, based on the terms of the loan, and can move up or down within set limits.

The Benefits of Working with a Real Estate Professional

Buying a home is one of the biggest steps you'll take—and having the right professional by your side can make all the difference. A trusted buyer specialist is there to guide you through the process, saving you time, money, and stress.

Your buyer specialist will:

- Explain Buyer Agency and their responsibilities to you, including loyalty, confidentiality, full disclosure, and accountability.
- Walk you through financing options and, if needed, connect you with trusted mortgage professionals.
- Search the market for homes that match your needs and budget, saving you hours of time and effort.
- Share your home requirements with top-producing agents in the area, ensuring you get access to the best opportunities.
- Tour homes with you and provide side-by-side comparisons to help you make informed decisions.
- Recommend qualified home inspectors who can give detailed evaluations of properties.
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With Team D.B, you don't just get an agent—you get a partner who is fully invested in helping you secure the right home, at the right price, with confidence.



The Benefits of Working with a Real Estate Professional

- Provide expert guidance on your written offer to purchase a home, ensuring all terms are clear and approved by you.
- Negotiate the best possible price and terms on your behalf while managing all documentation details.
- Keep you informed every step of the way through the closing process.
- Connect you with any additional home-related services you may need.

In short, real estate professionals are the rock stars of the industry. The service, expertise, and peace of mind they provide are invaluable.

Ready to get started?

Complete the Home Search Worksheet to gain a clearer understanding of the type of home you're looking for.

Good luck, and happy house hunting!



This information is deemed reliable but is not guaranteed and is not intended to constitute professional advice. For such advice, please consult professional advisors.

